

Snow leopard

Panthera uncia



To local people, snow leopards are “mountain ghosts” because they are so well camouflaged that they are as good as invisible even at close range. They are the most elusive, most secretive, and smallest of the big cats—and the only one that cannot roar. Snow leopards are among the planet’s most endangered species. The estimated 4,000–7,000 remaining in the wild live mainly in the harsh mountain ranges of Central Asia, at elevations of 10,000–16,400 ft (3,000–5,000 m). They are still hunted illegally in “retribution” for killing livestock or for use in traditional medicine and for their pelts.

Fighting the cold

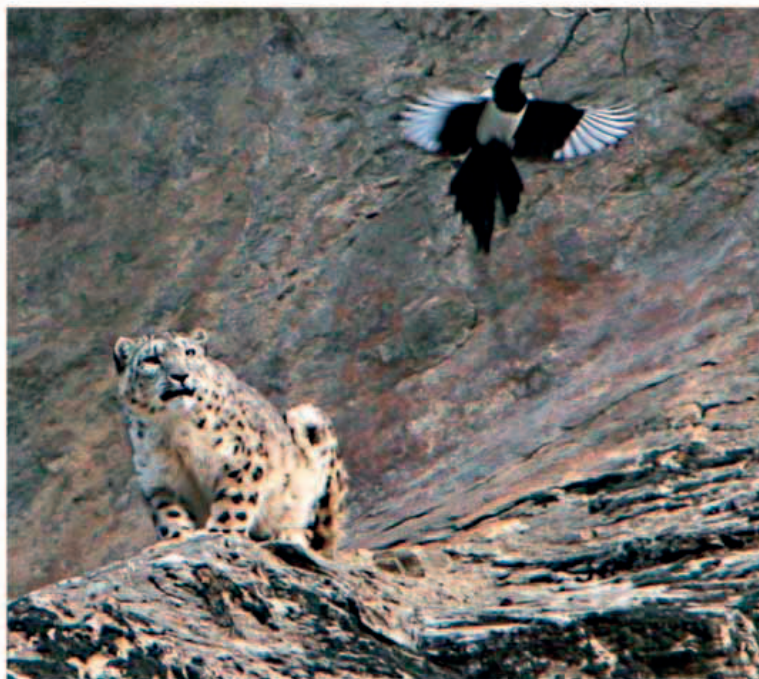
The snow leopard’s thick, creamy gray coat dotted with brown and gray-black spots blends in seamlessly with a rocky or scrub-filled landscape, while its dense, white underside hair merges into the snow. Even the pads of its feet are covered with fur, as is the long, thick tail, which serves both as a balancing aid and a furry scarf, wrapping around its body and face when the animal is at rest. Short, rounded ears, also covered in dense fur, minimize heat loss, and a wider-than-average nasal cavity warms incoming air before it reaches the lungs. Short forelimbs and huge, snowshoelike forepaws give

The snow leopard is the **only big cat that cannot roar**

snow leopards extra traction in the snow. The longer, powerful hind legs let it leap as far as 50 ft (15 m) while chasing after prey such as wild sheep (argali and bharal) or wild goats such as ibex.

Lone hunters

Aside from the mating season and mothers raising cubs, snow leopards live and hunt alone, traveling far in search of food. Due to the harsh nature of their environment, which stretches across the Himalayas to the Hindu Kush mountains, a snow leopard will patrol an average home range of 100 sq miles (260 sq km), marking the landscape with urine and feces that act as scent signals to other snow leopards. Females have litters of two or three cubs, which stay with their mother until they are 18–22 months old.



△ ATTRACTING A MATE

When a female snow leopard is ready to mate, she may climb to a ridge or peak and make long, wailing cries to attract nearby males.

◁ MISSED OPPORTUNITY

Although wild sheep and goats are preferred prey, snow leopards eat small mammals such as lemmings and hares—and birds when they can catch them.